

Chandrababu Naidu

TDP

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- Can gain from anti-incumbency factor against the Congress Government in Andhra Pradesh.
- Managed to forge a grand alliance with the CPI, CPI(M) and the TRS—all former Congress allies.
- With his meticulous managerial skills he can rally together egocentric regional party leaders.

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- Chiranjeevi's Praja Rajyam offers stiff resistance to his plans to make a comeback in the state.
- Unlike many other Third Front partners, he can't join a Congress-led government.
- With Mayawati and Jayalalithaa ruling supreme in the Third Front, his chances are limited.



A PRABHAKAR RAO

AS IT'S NOT A FRONT UNITED BY IDEOLOGY OR A COMMON MINIMUM PROGRAMME, ALL WILL DEPEND ON THE TERMS OF POWER SHARING.

time. When the Congress lost the space that historically belonged to it in Uttar Pradesh, it was not taken by a national party like the BJP. The SP and the BSP shared the space vacated by the Congress. In Bihar, it was the Janata Dal and eventually Lalu's RJD that replaced the Congress. In Maharashtra, it was not the BJP but the Shiv Sena that first challenged the formidable Congress. In Tamil Nadu, the Congress needs either the DMK or AIADMK. Today, the party has no leaders who could stand up to regional satraps. In states like Punjab, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, the BJP grew not by competing with the anti-Congress regional parties but by aligning with them. Geography is also coming to their help. The Congress, which peaked its performance last time in southern states, will give away much of its seats due to anti-incumbency. Regional parties, not the BJP, will be the gainers.

The prime minister may still argue that the growth of the Third Front is only helping the BJP but the gung-ho Karat has a different explanation: "It is not the Congress, but the non-Congress, non-BJP alternative which has effectively put paid to the chances of the BJP coming to power at the Centre. The BJP cannot even make its mark in states like Tamil Nadu, Orissa and Andhra Pradesh where its traditional allies have joined the Third Front as the secular alternative is emerging stronger with more UPA allies falling in line". Both the BJP and the Congress are keen to minimise the Third Front threat by suggesting that, once in power, it will collapse under its own weight—like the Janata experiment in 1977-80. Apologists for the Third Way may argue that the governments of V.P. Singh (1989-90), Deve Gowda (1996-97) and I.K. Gujral (1997-98) were all toppled by the BJP or Congress. Then, those gentlemen were in power courtesy the support of either or both.

Lest history does not repeat as a farce, regional parties are banking on what some pundits call as the "Baali-